

Traps are lessons in causes

Opening Decisions

THE IDEA

An opening trap is useful when it teaches a recurring tactical cause: a loose piece, an unsafe king, or a pinned defender. Memorizing a trick without understanding its conditions makes you vulnerable when the opponent changes one move.

WORKED EXAMPLE

The sequence 1.f3 e5 2.g4 Qh4# demonstrates how moving the f- and g-pawns can expose the king's diagonal. Its value is the king-safety lesson, not the expectation that opponents will repeat the same moves.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What should you extract from studying a trap?

ANSWER AND REASONING

The vulnerable square, the missing defender, and the move that opened the line. Then ask which defensive move would remove the combination before it begins.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Learn why a trap works and when it stops working.